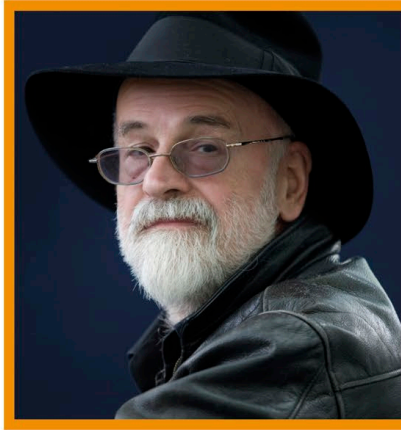


See also: The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229 ■ The European Convention on Human Rights 230–233
■ *Roe v. Wade* 260–263 ■ The Dickey–Wicker Amendment 284

suicide (sometimes called physician-assisted suicide or assisted dying) means deliberately offering help to someone who wants to kill him- or herself—for example, when a physician gives the patient lethal drugs to take. Some see the term “assisted dying” as different, because it specifies that the patient must have a terminal illness and be in the last 6 months of life, but in practice, the two phrases tend to be used interchangeably.

Moves to legalization

Opinion in the West has begun to tilt in favor of euthanasia. The Netherlands was the first country to legalize it, in 2001, with effect from 2002, followed by Belgium in 2002 and by Luxembourg and Colombia in 2020. Assisted suicide was legalized in Canada in 2016; in nine US states and Washington, DC, between 1997 and 2020; and in the Australian states of Victoria and Western Australia in 2019. The Netherlands, Belgium, and Luxembourg all made assisted suicide legal at the same time as euthanasia. Although euthanasia



British author Terry Pratchett, best known for his fantasy novels such as the *Discworld* series, became an advocate for assisted dying after he was diagnosed with Alzheimer’s.

euthanasia and assisted suicide, the patient must be suffering from “an incurable disorder,” they must be “conscious and competent,” and they must supply a written request. If death is not imminent, there must be a second medical opinion to back the original decision in favor of euthanasia, and there must be a delay of at least 1 month between the formal request and the act itself. Almost exactly the same conditions are in place in the Netherlands.

Public opinion

Euthanasia remains illegal in most Western nations, but in Britain, where it is also a crime, public opinion polls in 2019 showed a shift in support for euthanasia at 84 percent. Medical opinion, however, remains divided over a legal means of ending life for those in intolerable pain. ■

is prohibited in Switzerland, the country has allowed assisted suicide since 1942 and is unique in that it offers assisted suicide to foreign nationals. In each of these countries where it is legal, permitted circumstances vary widely, such as the condition of the patient and the age requirement. In 2014, for example, Belgium dropped all age restrictions.

Further guidelines

In all cases, strict legal guidelines have been put in place. In Belgium, for example, which permits both

“

If an adult who is suffering and dying has requested euthanasia, why should others have the right to deny them?

Carmenza Ochoa
Right to a Dignified Death
Foundation, 2015

”

Fabiano Antoniani

Almost no case more exactly highlighted the arguments over assisted suicide than that of Italian DJ and music producer Fabiano Antoniani. In 2014, a car crash left him tetraplegic and blind—in essence, physically helpless but still mentally alert. His case was taken up by Italy’s leading campaigner for assisted suicide, Marco Cappato. In 2017, Cappato arranged for Antoniani to be taken to Switzerland, where, on February 27, at the

age of 40, he died from assisted suicide. Cappato was then charged with complicity in Antoniani’s death, facing 12 years in prison. In September 2019, Italy’s highest court declared him not guilty, saying that, in certain circumstances, anyone who “facilitates the suicidal intention ... of a patient kept alive by life-support treatments and suffering from an irreversible pathology” should not be punished.